

Laid Off? Why Apply For a New Job When You Can

Be a CEO?



The broader picture: freedom software can turn an engineer into a CEO.

The economy is crumbling. Jobs are being cut. Hope? It's floating. One severely hit sector in times like these is the software development industry. Even companies like Google and Microsoft can't escape the thunder and have had to lay people off in recent times.

Despite this depression, there is a silver lining behind the dark clouds—Freedom Software or Open Source is emerging as the saviour. But it's easier said than done. Let me present a hypothesis here on how Freedom Software saves careers and companies.

The fantastic four

There were four friends working in three different software companies. One fine day, they received pink slips out of the blue. Suddenly, the ones with heavy salaries and the most promising careers were jobless. They met in the evening, concerned about their present and future. They did have some savings and working spouses, so they could survive for a while without jobs. But the economy was not promising anything big.

One of the four friends was into sales and marketing. He confirmed, "Tomorrow, I was supposed to meet a client who is also feeling the heat. The pressure from the US government to cut outsourcing, along with the economic slowdown, was already crushing their outsourcing business."

Apparently the company was waiting for a big contract from their customer, but was required to scale up for that project. To do so, the firm needed to buy new licences for the proprietary products it used. The firm was

reluctant to invest its savings in the current hard times, on something that it was not 100 per cent sure would materialise. Also, the firm could not access funds from banks. If the firm took the risk of investing its savings to scale up, only to find that another firm had out-bid it to win the contract, it'd go bankrupt. Ironically, if it did not scale up, it would still lose the project and go downhill pretty soon.

One of the friends was a software consultant. He offered, "Why don't we meet this client and see if we can help. Either way, we are now jobless and have lots of time to spare."

The four went to meet the client. They surveyed the firm's infrastructure, which was running completely on proprietary technologies. For every new box, the firm would have to buy new licences. After visiting the centre, the four decided to suggest something that could save the firm.

The suggestion

"Migrate to Open Source."

"What?" the owner said. "How can I migrate to Open Source during a running project? And where am I going to get the money for it? And even if it's all possible, who in the world would be able to take up the job of migrating our entire infrastructure?"

The consultant told him that either way he'd have to invest money in buying or renewing licences. If he chose open source, they could bring the cost down dramatically. Most of what he was running had successful freedom software alternatives.

It all boiled down to who would do